

Session 17: The Flood Waters Recede

Key Takeaways

- The restoration of people and animals to the land after the flood is both a re-creation and a new creation.
- Creation in the biblical imagination is about more than where things began; it’s about the transition from non-order to order and the transition from death to life.
- Noah, his family, and the animals exit the ark on the first day of the calendar—the new creation coinciding with the start of the year. This pattern recurs throughout Scripture.

God’s New Creation Spirit-Wind

The image of God’s *ruakh* (רוח) blowing over the watery chaos links back to Genesis 1:2.

Genesis 8:1 Instructor's Translation

And *Elohim* caused a ***ruakh*** to pass over the land, and **the waters** subsided.

Genesis 1:2 Instructor's Translation

Now, the land was wild and waste
and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss
but the ***ruakh*** of *Elohim* was hovering over the face of **the waters**.

This is the first allusion in a network of allusions to Genesis 1. All these allusions portray the recession of the waters as a re-creation narrative on analogy with Genesis 1. Joshua Berman shows how nearly all of the narrative elements in Genesis 8-9 adapt vocabulary from Genesis 1 in the precise order of the days of creation.

Day		Creation: Genesis 1	Re-Creation: Genesis 8-9	
First Day	1:2	• The land was wild and waste • Darkness over the deep (<i>tehom</i>) • And the <i>ruakh</i> of <i>Elohim</i> was hovering over the waters	8:1b–2a	• And <i>Elohim</i> caused a <i>ruakh</i> to pass over and the land, and the waters receded
Genesis 8-9 Re-Creation. Adapted from Berman, Joshua (2017). <i>Inconsistency in the Torah</i> . Oxford University Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).				

Day	Creation: Genesis 1		Re-Creation: Genesis 8-9	
Second Day	1:6–8	• Separation of the waters above and the waters below	8:2b	• And the springs of the deep and the windows of the heavens were closed
Third Day	1:9	• Water gathered into one place and the dry ground appeared • Vegetation comes out of the ground	8:3–5, 11	• Waters return from the land and the tops of the mountains appeared • Dove returns with fresh olive branch
Fourth Day	1:14-19	• Sun and moon appointed to rule the boundaries of morning and evening	8:11	• Dove returns at time of evening
Fifth Day	1:20	• Let birds fly above the earth against the face of the sky dome	8:12	• Dove leaves the ark to return to the sky and land
Sixth Day	1:24	• Creation of living creatures, livestock, creepers on the ground	8:17	• Animals leave the ark, living creatures, livestock, creepers on the ground
	1:26	• Human is the image of God	9:6	• Human is the image of God
	1:29	• “There will be food for you”	9:3	• “There will be food for you”
Seventh Day	2:1-3	• “God rested” (<i>shabbat</i>) • “God blessed”	8:4, 22 9:1	• The ark “rested” (<i>nuakh</i>) • God “blessed” • The seasons “will not rest” (<i>shabbat</i>)
<i>Genesis 8-9 Re-Creation.</i> Adapted from Berman, Joshua (2017). <i>Inconsistency in the Torah</i> . Oxford University Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).				

The Flood Waters Recede from the Land: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:2-5

The recession of the flood waters is described as the inversion of the flood’s beginning.

- a ² And **they were closed**,
- b the **fountains of the deep**
- b' and **the windows of the skies**,
- a **and it was restrained**,
- b' the rain **from the skies**.

- a ³ And **the waters turned back** from upon the land,
- b going back and **the waters decreased**
- c at the end of one hundred and fifty days,

- a ⁴ and **the ark rested**,
- b in the seventh month,
- b' on the seventeenth day of the month,
- a' **upon the mountains of Ararat**.

- a ⁵ And **the waters were going and decreasing**
- b until the tenth month;
- b' in the tenth month,
- b'' on the first day of the month,
- a **the heads of the mountains** became visible.

Genesis 8:2-5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The Flood Reversed

This description is designed to precisely reverse the vocabulary and narrative movement of the waters’ rising in Genesis 7:17-20.

Genesis 8:2-5	Genesis 7:11-12, 17-20
² And they were closed, the fountains of the deep and the windows of the skies, and it was restrained, the rain from the skies.	¹¹ And they split open, the fountains of the great deep burst open, and the windows of the skies were opened. ¹² And there was rain upon the land
³ And the waters turned back from upon the land, going back and the waters decreased	¹⁷ And the flood was forty days upon the land, and the waters were great
<i>The Flood Waters Recede From the Land.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Genesis 8:2-5	Genesis 7:11-12, 17-20
at the end of one hundred and fifty days,	and they lifted up the ark, and it rose up over the land.
⁴ and the ark rested, in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, upon the mountains of Ararat.	¹⁸ And the waters were mighty, and they were very great upon the land, and the ark went on the face of the waters.
⁵ And the waters were going and decreasing until the tenth month; in the tenth month, on the first day of the month, the heads of the mountains became visible.	¹⁹ And the waters were mighty, very very much, upon the land, and they covered all the high mountains which are under the skies, ²⁰ fifteen cubits above, the waters were mighty, and they covered the mountains.
<i>The Flood Waters Recede From the Land.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

- The waters above and below were released, later they are closed.
- The ark was lifted and rose up high. Then the ark rests and touches down.
- The waters were great and increased over the land. The waters recede and turn back.
- The waters covered the mountains. The heads of the mountains are revealed.

Mount Ararat

Notice that the narrator doesn't say which particular mountain the ark rested upon. The narrator simply says that it came to rest in "the mountains of Ararat."

The word "Ararat" (Heb. אֲרָרָט) is derived from Akkadian *Urartu*, and it refers to the region that today is on the far eastern border of Turkey, near Armenia. It's a highland hill country north of Mesopotamia in between Lake Van and the Caspian Sea. There are a number of high peaks that tower above the horizon.



Serouj Ourishian (2016). [Wikipedia](#)

Interestingly, in other Mesopotamian flood stories like the Epic of Gilgamesh, Utnapishtim's ark rests on "Mount Nimush" in the Zagros mountains on the eastern border of today's Iran and Iraq (some 400 miles from Mount Ararat). However, in Berossus' account, he names the region similar to the biblical account, in the mountains of Armenia. For more information, see John Day's "The Flood and the Ten Antediluvian Figures in Berossus and in the Priestly Source in Genesis" (Day, 2011. 65-67.).

Notice that the name Ararat forms an elaborate wordplay on Noah's birth story in Genesis 5:29. The Ararat wordplay relates to what Noah will do on this mountain when he gets out of the boat.

Noah's Naming

Genesis 5:28-29 NASB*

²⁸ And Lemek lived one hundred and eighty-two years, and he caused the birth of a son.

²⁹ And he called his name "Noah (נח)," saying,

"This one will give us **comfort (נחם)** from our work and from the toil of our hands from **the ground (האדמה)** which the LORD has **cursed (אררה)**."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Post-Flood Connections

Genesis 8:4 NASB*

and the ark **rested (נוח)** in the mountain of **Ararat (אררט)**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 8:18-21 Instuctor's Translation

¹⁸ Noah went out from the ark ... ²⁰ And he built an altar to Yahweh and he caused an offering to go up on the altar, ²¹ and Yahweh smelled the **restful smell (ניחוח)** and Yahweh said to his heart, "I will never again curse (קלל) **the ground (האדמה)** on account of humanity."

Noah's name, rest (*noakh*), alludes to his destiny, which is to bring comfort (*nakhham*) to the ground that God has cursed (*'erarah*). So Noah's ark rests (נָוָח) in the mountains of "carse" (*'ararat*) and offers a sacrificial smell (*nikhoakh*), and God says he won't curse the ground anymore.

In the Seventh Month, on the 17th Day

Noah's time on the ark has been coordinated with Israel's liturgical calendar that appears much later in the Torah (Lev. 23). The seventh month is the Fall new year celebration, and the 17th day is right in the middle of the festival of *Sukkot*/Tabernacles.

Given the importance of the ark as a proto-temple, this cannot be without significance: The ark, as a proto-tabernacle, goes through the chaos waters and comes to rest on a cosmic mountain at the same time of the year when the Israelites will later live in their micro-tabernacles during the feast of *Sukkot* to recall their journey through the desert on their way to the promised land.

Recall how in Genesis 1:2 the chaos waters and the desert are the two primary images of a non-ordered realm.

Noah, the Birds, and the Drying Land: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:6-14

- a 6 And it came about at the end of forty days,
b and Noah opened the window of the ark which he had made;
7 and he sent out a raven,
and it flew here and there until the waters were dried up from upon the land.

- A
a 8 And he sent out a dove from him,
b to see if the waters were abated from the face of the ground;
c 9 and the dove found no place of rest (מנוח) for the sole of its foot,
c' and it returned to him into the ark,
b' because the waters were on the surface of all the land.
a' And he sent out his hand and took it,
a' and he brought it into the ark to himself.

- B
10 And he waited yet another seven days;
and again he sent out the dove from the ark.
11 And the dove came to him at the time of evening,
and behold, in its mouth was an olive leaf, freshly picked,
and Noah knew that the waters were abated from upon the land.

12 **And he waited yet another seven days,**
A' **and he sent out the dove ;**
and **it did not again return to him .**

- a 13 **And it came about in the six hundred and first year,**
b **in the first month,**
b' **on the first of the month,**
c **the waters** were **dried up** from upon **the land ;**
d **and Noah removed the covering of the ark ,**
c' and he looked, and behold, the face of **the land** was **dried up**.
b' 14 **And in the second month,**
b' **on the twenty-seventh day of the month,**
c' **the land** was **dry**.

Genesis 8:6-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Spying Birds in Mesopotamian Flood Accounts

The sending out of the raven and the dove is one of the most well-known parallels between the flood stories in the Epic of Gilgamesh, the account of Berossus, and the biblical account.

When the seventh day arrived,
I released **a dove** to go free,
The dove went and returned,
No landing place came to view, **it turned back**.
I released **a swallow** to go free,
The swallow went and returned,
No landing place came to view, **it turned back**.
I sent **a raven** to go free,
The raven went forth, saw the ebbing of the waters,
It ate, circled, left droppings, **did not turn back**.

Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11

After the waters of the Great Flood had come and quickly left, Xisuthrus **freed several birds**. They **found neither food nor a place to rest, and they returned** to the ship. After a few days, he again **set free some other birds**, and **they too came back** to the they ship, but **they returned with claws covered with mud**. Then later for **a third time he set free some other birds**, but **they did not return** to the ship.

Berossus' Babylonica, paragraph 54

It's clear that the sending out of the birds was a standard motif in the tradition used by the biblical author, who adapted this scene to his own purposes by the introduction of strategic vocabulary.

Recalling the Days of Genesis 1

The sequence of Genesis 8:1-9:6 replays the key vocabulary of the days of creation in Genesis 1.

- The repetition of “seven days” two times activates the pattern of seven days in Genesis 1.
- The dove’s return “at the time of the evening” recalls day four, when the sun and moon are appointed as rulers who divide the day from the night.
- The variety of birds recalls day five: the birds who fly above the waters.

The 3 + 1 Test of Noah

Noah first sends out a raven, an omnivorous bird and therefore ritually impure (see Lev. 11:15). It does not return to the ark, presumably because it can find food out among the waters.

Noah then sends out a dove, a vegetarian and ritually pure bird (see Lev. 1:14; 5:7), and it cannot find food until the dry land appears.

The threefold sending out of the bird is a kind of test that Noah uses to make sure the divine promise is really taking place. This makes sense of why the narrator slows down the story, unnecessarily as far as the plot is concerned, to retell the dove scene in language reminiscent of the garden of Eden test.

Genesis 8:8-11 Instructor's Translation

⁸ And he sent out a dove from him,
to see if the waters were abated (קלל) from the face of the ground.

⁹ And the dove found no place of rest for the sole of its foot,
and it returned to him into the ark,
because the waters were on the surface of all the land.

And he sent out his hand and took it (שלח + יד + לקח)

and he brought her to himself (בוא + אליו) into the ark

¹⁰ and he waited yet another seven days;
and again he sent out the dove from the ark.

¹¹ And the dove came to him at the time of evening,
and behold, in its mouth was an olive **leaf (עלה)**, freshly picked,
and Noah knew (ידע) that the waters were abated (קלל) from upon the land,

Literary Connections to the Eden Test

- קלל is a homonym for “curse,” parallel to ארר in Genesis 3:14, 17
- “**So that he doesn’t send out his hand and take (שלח + יד + לקח)** also from the tree of life” (Gen. 3:22)
- “**And he brought her to the human (בוא + אליו)**” (Gen. 2:22)
- “**And they knew (ידע)** that they were naked and they sewed a fig tree **leaf (עלה)** and made garments for themselves” (Gen. 3:7)

In Genesis 3, God is testing the humans’ faithfulness to him, while in Genesis 8, Noah is testing God’s faithfulness to him.

- God “brought the woman to the human,” and she becomes the means through which the humans fail the test of following God’s command. In the same way, the bird is Noah’s means of testing God’s promise to deliver him, so he “brings her to himself.”
- Adam and Eve “send out their hand and take” from the wrong tree, which is the object of their test. In the same way, Noah sends out his hand to take the dove, which is his way of testing God’s promise.
- The humans take the **knowing** of good and bad, **know** they are naked, and so they use a **leaf** to cover over their failure. In the same way, Noah sends out a dove as a test and the **leaf** becomes the way he **knows** that God has kept his promise.

Flood Recession = New Creation

The date of the recession of the floodwaters has been coordinated with the Torah’s chronology of creation, Passover, and the inauguration of the tabernacle.

Genesis 8:13 NASB*

Now it came about in the **six hundred and first year**, **in the beginning (בראשון)**, **on the first of the month**, the water was dried up from the earth. Then Noah removed the covering of the ark, and looked, and behold, the surface of the ground was dried up.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 1:1-2 Instructor’s Translation

¹ **In the beginning (בראשית)** God created the skies and the land. ² Now the land was wild and waste and darkness was over the deep waters, but the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters ...

Exodus 12:1-2 NASB

¹ Now the LORD said to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, ² “This month shall be **the beginning (ראשון)** of months for you; it is to be **the first month of the year** to you.

Exodus 40:1-2 NASB*

¹ Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying, ² “On the **first day of the beginning (ראשון) month** you shall set up the tabernacle of the tent of meeting.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“According to the ... chronology the new world emerged from the flood waters on the first day of the liturgical year, the same day on which the tabernacle was set up and dedicated in the wilderness (Gen. 8:13; Exod. 40:2). It will be recalled that the first temple was also dedicated during Sukkoth, the autumnal New Year Festival (1 Kgs. 8:2, 65). We are also told that it took seven years to build which ... is related to the seven days of creation. The same dating system requires that the week of creation in Gen 1:1-2:4 be the first week of the liturgical year or, in other words, the primordial New Year Festival.”

Blenkinsopp, Joseph (1976). "The Structure of P". *Catholic Biblical Association* Vol. 38, (No. 3). 283-284.

Divine Speech Summons Noah to Leave the Ark: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:15-19

A 15 And Elohim spoke to Noah, saying,

16 “ **Go out** from the ark,

B **you and your wife**
and your sons and your sons’ wives with you.

17 **From every living thing with you**

B’ **from all flesh,**
birds and animals
and every creeper that creeps on the land,

A’ **make them go out** with you,

so they can swarm in the land
and be fruitful and multiply in the land .”

A 18 And Noah **went out** ,

B **and his sons and his wife**
and his sons’ wives with him.

19 **Every living thing,**

B’ **every creeper,**
and every bird,
everything that creeps on the land,

A’ by their families **they went out** from the ark.

Genesis 8:15-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The command and fulfillment structure of this scene creates an orderly and processional feel to the exit from the ark. This description of the exit from the ark precisely matches the narrative of their entrance into the ark in 6:17-22.

Entering the Ark		Exiting the Ark	
Command	6:18-20 ¹⁸ And you will go into the ark you and your sons and your wife, and your sons' wives with you. ¹⁹ And of every living thing of all flesh, two of everything you will make go into the ark, to keep them alive with you; they shall be male and female. ²⁰ Of the birds after their kind, and of the animals after their kind, of every creeping thing of the ground after its kind, two of every kind will go to you to keep them alive.	8:15-17 ¹⁵ And Elohim spoke to Noah, saying, ¹⁶ "Go out from the ark, you and your wife and your sons and your sons' wives with you. ¹⁷ From every living thing with you from all flesh, birds and animals and every creeper on the land, make them go out with you ...	
Fulfillment	7:13-16 ¹³ On that very day Noah went and Shem and Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah, and Noah's wife and the three wives of his sons with them, into the ark, ¹⁴ they, and every living creature after its kind, and all the beasts after their kinds, and every creeper that creeps on the land after its kind, and every bird after its kind, every bird of every wing. ¹⁵ And they went to Noah, into the ark, two by two, from all flesh in which was the breath of life, ¹⁶ and those going, male and female of all flesh ...	8:18-19 ¹⁸ And Noah went out, and his sons and his wife and his sons' wives with him. ¹⁹ Every living thing, every creeper, and every bird, everything that creeps on the land, by their families they went out from the ark.	
<i>Entering the Ark and Exiting the Ark. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>			

This elaborate emphasis on the entrance into and exit from the temple-ark gives the narrative a liturgical feel, as if we are watching a procession into and out of the temple that passes through the "gate" to experience divine presence and deliverance.

Families of the Animals

As Noah and his family get off the ark, they exit parallel to all the animals “by their families” (Heb. *mishpakhah* / משפחה). This word appears 303 times in the Hebrew Bible, and this first appearance of the term is also the only time it is used of non-humans. In the parallel panel of 7:13-16, the animals are grouped together by species using the word “kind” (מין), a word used in Genesis 1:21, 24-25.

In deliberate contrast to “kind,” the narrator in Genesis 8:18-29 calls the animal species “families” as they exit along with Noah and his sons, who will become the three main families of the biblical world in Genesis 10. In fact, the word family will be used next of just these three sons (Gen. 10:5, 20, 31).

This creates an “animal families / human families” parallel, which is drawn upon in the prophets in a big way, like in the two framing visions of Isaiah 2 and 11.

Reflection Question

If the arrival of the flood was a cosmic collapse, then God’s salvation of humanity, the animals, and the land through the waters is an act of new creation. How do the biblical authors connect the post-flood restoration to creation?